neither smooth, nor inevitable. Many technologies were invented before the scientific principles on which they are based are known (steam engine is one example). Emerging technologies often compete. The choice of technologies as well as the way they are designed and developed are influenced by social as well as technical factors.

For *Economic determinists*, technologies are developed and selected to suit the prevailing economic conditions, for example, relative scarcity of land, labour, capital, and the products and services that are developed depend on market demand. The technologies which are a commercial success in the market are those that are widely adopted. However, economic determinism does not explain the development of technologies where there is no profit motive or market demand such as space research, military technology and even medical technology. Nor does it explain why the cheapest means of production is not always the one that is adopted.

More recently, the scholars of technological change tend to argue that the invention and engineering design process is guided and shaped by the goals of the designers and their *employers* or *clients*. This is why, they argue that it is misleading to consider technologies as neutral or the inevitable result of progress . Basically, long before any technology is offered for use in the market, a process of selection occurs that is guided by social and political, as well as economic, considerations. This is why we have been seeing many report across the world in which the developers of a new technique or medicine have been blamed of concealing harmful effects. Recently, ‘swine-flu’ was almost declared to the proportion of a pandemic in which a ‘WHO-drug manufacturer’ connivance was highlighted.

TECHNOLOGY – AS MEANS OF RESOURCE USE

The reality of *environmental degradation* can be described as a product of population, resource use per person (affluence) and environmental damage per unit of resource used (technology). In the negotiation at the Earth Summit in Rio de Janeiro in June 1992, the USA wanted to remove all references to consumption (resource use per person) from the Agenda 21 document (the proposed plan of action for the 21st century). The US